

Behavioral Health and Special Education Subcommittee Meeting Notes

January 21, 2021

5 - 6:30 Via Zoom

Live Transcription/closed captioning provided

5:03 Roll: Melanie McLaughlin, Chair

Subcommittee Member, Mea Mustone, absent

Subcommittee Member, Paul Ruseau, present

Paulette Van der Kloot, SC member present

Behavioral Health:

Our last meeting was November. December meeting was scheduled on what turned out to be a snow day.

Stacey Schulman, Director of School Counseling and Behavioral Health.

Trauma informed schools and Stress.

Medford has sent out surveys to students and faculty in high school regarding homework induced stress.

The Nan Project: partnership through Eliott Health and Human Services

It was created as a way to talk to students about mental health by specifically bringing in peer mentors who have experienced mental illness. Purpose is to show students that 95% of people with mental health issues overcome them with support.

This was done over zoom during advisory blocks.

In the past they have come in person and have had parent nights. They also do professional development.

Jake Kavanaugh, founded this project in dedication to his sister Nan who committed suicide.

Melanie McLaughlin: Suggested they do a parent night on zoom.

Homework Survey 12.20:

Stacey Schulman shared powerpoint.

There was a lot of conversation amongst faculty and students about too much homework and not enough homework. Hypothesis that students were feeling they were having a lot of homework but that it was actually carry over of asynchronous work.

781 students responded to the survey.

How many hours do you spend on homework in all subjects (not between 7:40 and 2:18)?

Compared to last year, homework load is? 42.3% said more than last year. 16.9% more than last year.

There is a divide between students and faculty. Students believe they have more than the teachers feel they give.

Question: were they instructed not to include asynchronous work?

Stacey Schulman: no they were not.

Paul Ruseau: Were they asked what cohort they were in?

Paul D'Alleva: No they were not. At the point they were given the survey, only cohort A was in the building.

Paul Ruseau: It would be interesting to see if the remote kids are responding with more work than the hybrid kids.

Paul D'Alleva: One thing I took away from the surveys is the need to define what is asynchronous work and what is homework? In this survey all kids aside from cohort a, were remote at the time. There were also discussions about where they need to be in their curriculum as well. What has been lost? What needs to be gained back? It can be overwhelming. Teachers are talking to teachers to determine what is being done about managing assignments. Teachers in one content area are not necessarily communicating with other content area teachers about assignments. Some students take longer to do assignments than others.

Melanie McLaughlin: Is there still common planning time?

Paul D'Alleva: Yes but not for every single subject at the same time. Freshman collaborative was 9th grade teachers having the time to collaborate to share what they are assigning for 9th graders. This was happening before COVID. Harder to do at higher grades because of Honors and AP. Special Education teachers have co-teaching model.

Melanie McLaughlin: there is not a grade level common planning time?

Paul D'Alleva; Gets tricky because grade levels combine within advanced classes. Our teachers also teach a mix of grade levels in their content areas. We like our teachers to be diversified like that to accommodate student needs.

Melanie McLaughlin: Do you have any recommendations on how this issue can be communicated across content areas? For homework

Paul D'Alleva: In light of the data that was collected, we wanted people to see what was happening according to the content area. I drew up a proposal for everyone to review: defining difference between homework and asynchronous work. We are still in final touches and are coming up with certain days in certain subjects and rotating the days keeping a time limit on certain subjects. Week A, Monday and Tuesday will be STEM, Wednesday will be World Language, Thursday and Friday will be Humanities. We are trying to isolate the subject as well as time to thirty minutes. Everyone ranges on how they do work. We are trying to find

commonality. In Advanced Placement, we have to present the syllabus to the college board and have to abide by it. The preparedness needs to be there regardless of the time. We met with the curriculum directors to make adjustments to the pacing guides and still keep the standards that DESE gives us in mind.

Melanie McLaughlin: It would be great to share with SC

Mr. Gertman: It would be great to include parents in future surveys. Klds could be taking numerous breaks in the middle of assignments. AP Expectation traditionally expects an hour per subject.

Melanie McLaughlin: Let's talk about a webinar for parents? School adjustment counselors did prepare webinars on depression and anxiety. If we are looking at community ed, what subject would be most helpful at this time?

Melanie McLaughlin: We can ask students what would be most helpful. I will include that on our agenda for our next meeting. In the meantime, we can do a bit of legwork on this. We can also take a look at Professional Development that this subcommittee can put forth as a policy recommendation. Please give some thought around what you might like to see proposed around mental health/behavioral health in our district? Speak to your students about what they feel will be important. Next meeting: February 11, 2021

Special Education: 5:45

Question of practice: how can we facilitate meaningful inclusionary friendships for students?

Former suggestions: Best Buddies Program, Siblings support group, participating in community activities

Heather and Marissa from Autism Support group have been working hard getting background information on Best Buddies. The Autism Support group is having a meeting next Thursday about support families with autism can seek.

Melanie McLaughlin: I shared folders of resources in google drive and invite others to share resources they find that can be helpful to others. I would like to create a database of supporters and volunteers who have this interest in our community. Melanie shared this spreadsheet with the group. I will send a link to this google doc.

Authentic friends are horizontal friends.....on equal footing.

Paul Ruseau: You might want to move the spreadsheet with your school address.

Melanie McLaughlin: I am waiting to hear back from the superintendent on the best practice we should follow with this spreadsheet.

Supt. Marice Edouard-Vincent: For the school committee drive, that is exclusively school committee members. If it is to be shared outside, it should be kept in two places.

Melanie McLaughlin: For now, under my own personal gmail, I have created the resource folder. If it is decided that I should put it in a folder, we can address that. I would like to keep the security issues in mind and do this as safely as possible.

Mr. Gertman: Does MPS have a google drive? It would be great if MPS could create a resources account. Already have a website but could be a place to access forms. Make it accessible to mps google accounts

Kate Quinn from Medford Recreation, inclusive recreation activities. Currently have a bowling class. Hoping to offer swimming, bocce and fishing. Looking for volunteers. If you know students who might be interested, email kquinn@medford.ma.gov to get involved. Program going on 3 years.

Melanie McLaughlin: The rec dept has made a commitment to adaptive and inclusive programs. A parent mentioned that one of the programs had limited participation but had an age cutoff. What partnerships do you have with Medford SEPAC?

Alex Lauric, SEPAC (parent): my son loved the Parkour program. Maybe the age ranges could be considered?

Angelica (parent): My son is 8 years old and is in the Connections program. It would be a good opportunity to put all of the kids together across ages.

Kate Quinn: Great feedback. Please email me as I can make exceptions to joining a class when appropriate. What do you think is best? Elementary to middle and then a high school group.

Carla Andre: I would love to get more information about this program. We are trying to foster relationships in the building so it would be great to bring both friends into the sports program together.

Angelica (parent): Perhaps we can be open minded about bringing one to one into the typical programs as well.

Melanie McLaughlin: Flexibility and programming and support are essential. Inclusivity.

Charlotte Heim: We do need community based opportunities in inclusive environments to foster connections. I appreciate the effort.

Kate Quinn: I am definitely interested in collaborating with all of you. If I can get emails and we can connect.

Angelica (parent): How are you spreading the word about the adaptive programs? I don't have social media. How can we spread the word on this.

Kate Quinn: we are on facebook and the city web site. When you have an account on my rec, then you will get those emails. Maybe I can forward it to the schools and the schools can distribute.

Tonya Sullivan: Sepac would love to meet with you. Could the schools distribute the information?

Joan Bowen: I can help that happen. We can post them and try to get the information to as many families as possible.

Melanie McLaughlin: Getting back to the policy piece and our goal of building friendships, what are the next steps?

Common Ground program: idea that was mentioned today about continuing that theme and that model. Why not keep this common ground program and expand it (started by Michael Skorker and Carla Andre)

Carla Andre: overarching idea to provide more meaningful inclusion for students as well as to provide staff to help foster that. As far as policy.....Common Ground:

The class

The after school club

The recreation programs

Common ground curriculum (one day a month having students all together one day a month)

Michael Skorker: We have been doing this for three years. I have a class Diversity and Community Enrichment. The friendships formed authentically. Students eating lunch together. I would love to see this at all levels (elementary and middle schools as well). I would love to continue this moving forward.

Melanie McLaughlin: Looking at these friendships, I see that they are not adult led. It often leads people towards this work. I am so proud of the work Carla and Michael are doing at the high school and would love to see it brought to the middle school and eventually the elementary school. I can see a potential for a night out for common ground. Shout out to

Craig Drauschke and Carla Andre will be presenting at SEPAC on differentiating instruction.

Tonya Sullivan: April 14 is the date of that session on differentiated curriculum. My son absolutely loves the common ground program. What will funding look like for the Common Ground umbrella?

Michael Skorker: Emily McDaid wrote a great article about common ground for the transcript last year.

6:27 next meeting february 11

Melanie McLaughlin: Shout out to Suzanna Campbell running disability awareness pd - eliminating ableism.

Meeting ended 6:28